

Falling under AI’s aegis: War and taxes

As officials push use of tools across government, watchdogs warn of risks

BY DOUGLAS MACMILLAN, FAIZ SIDDIQUI, HANNAH NATANSON AND ELIZABETH DWOSKIN

Elon Musk has receded from Washington but one of his most disruptive ideas about government is surging inside the Trump administration.

Artificial intelligence, Musk has said, can do a better job than federal employees at many tasks — a notion being tested by AI projects trying to automate work across nearly every agency in the executive branch.

The Federal Aviation Administration is exploring whether AI can be a better air traffic controller. The Pentagon is using AI to help officers distinguish between combatants and civilians in the field, and said Monday that its personnel would begin using the chatbot Grok offered by Musk’s start-up xAI, which is trying to gain a foothold in federal agencies.

AI technology could soon play a central role in tax audits, airport security screenings and more, according to public documents and interviews with current and former federal workers.

Many of these AI programs aim to shrink the federal workforce — continuing the work of Musk’s U.S. DOGE Service, which has cut thousands of government employees. Government AI is also promised to reduce wait times and lower costs to American taxpayers.

Government tech watchdogs SEE AI ON A13



CAROLYN VAN HOUTEN/THE WASHINGTON POST

U.S. aid cuts deepen Afghans’ woe

Food, health care shortages grow acute as relief all but ends

BY RICK NOACK IN HATAM KHAIL, AFGHANISTAN

Nabila, 11, left, and her family in Hatam Khail are among over 3 million people in Afghanistan estimated to have been affected by the Trump administration’s foreign aid cuts.

Sometimes, Muhammad Usman thinks about what he would buy if he became rich. He would start with the basics, he said, which his family has gone without for months: a sack of flour, sugar, some cooking oil.

In March 2024, international donors delivered boxes of emergency food to his village, Hatam Khail, which is just an hour’s drive from Kabul, the Afghan capital, but feels much farther — blighted by decades of war and cut off from most basic services.

As they waited for the snow to melt around their mud brick house and for their cherry tree to blossom, Usman, his wife, and their six sons and grandchildren carefully rationed the donated goods. They expected more food would come during the winter. But it never did.

“Only one of my sons has work,” said Usman, holding out hands cracked by years of hard labor.

“Our government has provided nothing,” he said of the Taliban-run regime. “And now, no other country is helping anymore.”

During America’s 20-year war against the Taliban, successive U.S. presidents vowed never to abandon Afghanistan, one of the world’s poorest and most underdeveloped nations. When American troops withdrew in 2021 and the Taliban regained power, the United States remained the country’s largest humanitarian donor, accounting for more than 40 percent of all humanitarian support — helping stave off hunger and support health care providers.

That lifeline all but vanished when Donald Trump returned to the White House in January, swiftly announcing a pause in foreign assistance programs that he said were “not aligned with American interests and in many cases [were]”

SEE AFGHANISTAN ON A9

Atmospheric forces drive deadly flooding in U.S.

Experts: Warming ‘changes the odds’ for rainfall

BY BEN NOLL AND SCOTT DANCE

In the week and a half since floods killed at least 130 people in Central Texas, heavy rains have filled New York subway stations, submerged busy roadways and drowned two people in a vehicle in New Jersey. Storms have stranded Washington-area motorists. Deadly torrents returned to a flood- and fire-scarred region of New Mexico. And meanwhile, flooding rains have yet to relent in Texas.

Downpours and thunderstorms are a familiar signal of summer — but this one has been different. Barely halfway through, it’s already been a hyperactive season of often fatal flooding,

with more than twice as many floods as usual so far this July, according to National Weather Service reports.

While there are varying meteorological forces behind this month’s extreme rainfall, what has connected them all is significant amounts of atmospheric moisture pulsing above the country.

It is flowing from abnormally warm oceans across the Northern Hemisphere that are likely to stretch elevated flood risks into August, data shows — perhaps into record territory. The conditions are allowing plumes of tropical moisture to stretch into middle latitudes and stagnate there, sending flood risks surging and

SEE FLOODING ON A14



CRAIG HUDSON/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

A U.S. Postal Service vehicle drives down a waterlogged road in Northeast Washington on Monday.

Americans pull back on summer vacations amid warning signs on economy

BY ABHA BHATTARAI

Americans are downsizing their summer vacations — taking shorter trips, driving instead of flying, and generally staying closer to home in an uncertain economy.

Families appear to be pulling back on travel spending, after years of splurging on vacations and other experiences after the pandemic-era shutdowns. Fewer

households are booking airline tickets or hotel rooms now than they were a year ago, Bank of America data shows. And the number of people taking vacation time off work in June dropped to its lowest level since the pandemic, according to Labor Department data.

That pullback follows months of economic warning signs. Americans say they are feeling worse about the economy than they have

in years, as new trade and immigration policies take hold. Many are bracing for a spike in prices from new tariffs, while others are worried about losing their jobs in a slowing labor market.

Renewed tariff threats last week — including rates as high as 50 percent on goods from Brazil, Japan and Canada starting Aug. 1 — have added to fears that a new round of inflation may be around the corner. Consumer spending

dropped in May, as households put more of their incomes in savings in anticipation of higher costs.

In all, Americans expect to spend an average \$3,132 on summer vacations this year, about 25 percent less than the \$4,199 they set aside last summer, according to an annual survey conducted by Ipsos for Generali Global Assistance.

“The spending slowdown is real,” said Diane Swonk, chief

economist at KPMG. “Consumers are stressed, and this is where we’re seeing it first: in domestic flights, hotels, and a lot of other service-sector spending.”

Although the wealthiest Americans are still splurging on international travel and booking hotel rooms that cost \$800 a night or

SEE VACATIONS ON A18

Inflation up: Tariffs boosted prices across the economy in June. A18

\$9B in greenlit funding in peril

FOREIGN AID, NPR, PBS UNDER KNIFE

Bill advances as some in Senate GOP not yet sold

BY THEODORIC MEYER

The Senate voted Tuesday to advance President Donald Trump’s request to claw back \$9 billion in foreign aid and federal funding for public broadcasting despite the misgivings of some Republicans.

The vote was 51-50, with Vice President JD Vance breaking a tie after Sens. Susan Collins (R-Maine), Lisa Murkowski (R-Alaska) and Mitch McConnell (R-Kentucky) broke with their party and voted with Democrats.

Senators must now consider a series of other procedural hurdles and up to 10 hours of debate before a final floor vote; if that succeeds, the legislation would have to return to the House to be considered before Friday’s deadline.

The rescissions bill is a top priority for the Trump administration, which plans to use the same process to seek deeper cuts in the future if it passes. But some Senate Republicans balked at the cuts, leading Senate Majority Leader John Thune (R-South Dakota) to strip some of them

SEE SENATE ON A7

Radio silence: Bill would put public radio stations in jeopardy. B1

GOP’s rift on Epstein continues to widen

Speaker breaks with administration’s decision not to release files

BY MARIANNA SOTOMAYOR

One of the leading Republicans on Capitol Hill broke with the Trump administration’s decision not to release the files of deceased sex offender Jeffrey Epstein as the controversy deepened over the handling of an issue that has caused unprecedented division among the GOP base.

House Speaker Mike Johnson (R-Louisiana) told right-wing podcaster Benny Johnson on Tuesday that he supported the release of the Epstein files, days after President Donald Trump’s Justice Department said the matter was effectively closed. Johnson is a close Trump ally and has never broken so publicly with the president on an issue.

“I’m for transparency,” Johnson told Benny Johnson. “It’s a very delicate subject, but we should put everything out there and let the people decide it.”

Even as Johnson publicly called for the files to be released, he opposed a procedural motion advanced Tuesday by Democrats that would have set up a House vote to release them.

SEE EPSTEIN ON A4

IN THE NEWS

Education layoffs The Supreme Court’s decision to clear the way revived questions about how the agency will carry out its legally required duties with a slashed workforce. A6

D.C.’s Ward 8 Trayon White Sr., who was expelled after a bribery indictment, is poised to reclaim his seat in a special election. B13

THE NATION Pete Hegseth got into an angry confrontation at the Pentagon with a DOGE team leader. A3
University leaders faced tough questions in a House panel’s hearing on antisemitism. A5

THE WORLD Paris once again rolled out the Bastille Day doings that, years ago, inspired Trump. A8
As Trump leans toward Ukraine, Russians wonder whether a window has closed. A11

THE ECONOMY Hims & Hers joined forces with drugmaker Novo Nordisk to boost sales of Wegovy, then the pact abruptly fell apart. A12
China’s economy grew 5.3 percent in the first half of 2025, as exports surged during a trade war truce. A18

STYLE The Emmy nominations went about as expected Tuesday, though a few new shows were able to elbow in. B1

SPORTS Star wide receiver Terry McLaurin is “pretty frustrated” by his contract stalemate with the Commanders. B7

THE REGION A D.C. landlord is seeking to evict Rep. Cory Mills (R-Florida), alleging \$85,000 is owed in unpaid rent. B13

FOOD Tariffs on tea and coffee give yaupon, the only native caffeinated plant in the United States, a shot at stardom.

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